

⇒ Psychology:

- is the scientific study of behaviour and mental processes.

* Scientific - Psychology uses systematic, observation objective and empirical methods (e.g., experiments, observation, surveys) to gather variable data.

* Behavior - Observable actions like talking, walking, crying, eating - anything we can see or measure.

* Mental Processes - Internal experiences such as thoughts, emotions, memory, and motives that cannot be directly observed but can be inferred from behavior.

Example: If someone cries, psychology tries to understand both the behavior (crying) and the mental process (sadness, loss, or stress) behind it.

⇒ History of Psychology:

* Ancient Origins:

- In Ancient Egypt, the Edwin Smith Papyrus (around 1600 BCE) contained one of the earliest recorded observations about the brain's role in human functioning.

- Philosophers such as Plato and Aristotle in ancient Greece also debated the connection between the mind and body.

* Birth of Experimental Psychology:

• 1854 - Gustav Fechner (Germany):

- Developed the first theory on how humans make judgements about sensory experiences.

- His work laid the foundation for Signal Detection Theory, which explains how we detect faint signals amid background noise.

• 1879 - Wilhelm Wundt (Germany):

- Father of Psychology

- Founded first psychology laboratory in Leipzig.

- Marked the official beginning of psychology as a scientific discipline.

- Wundt focused on introspection, where people describe their conscious experiences in detail.

- He was the first person to identify as a psychologist.

* Development and Global Spread:

• G. Stanley Hall (1880s):

- Established the 1st psychology lab in the United States.

- Promoted scientific pedagogy - applying psychology to education.

• John Dewey (1890s):

- Developed educational theories that emphasized learning by doing and adapting lessons to real-life experiences.

- Considered one of the fathers of modern education.

* Behaviorism (Early 1900s)

- Founded by John B. Watson, later expanded by B.F. Skinner.

- Main focus: Study only observable and measurable behavior - not thoughts or feelings.

- Introduced the idea of conditioning:

• Classical Conditioning: Learning through association (Pavlov's dogs).

• Operant Conditioning: Learning through reward and punishment (Skinner).

Example: A student studies hard to get praised (reward) → increases studying behavior.

* Cognitive Revolution (Mid to Late 20th Century):

- Psychologists began to realize mental processes (thinking, memory, problem-solving) were crucial.

- This led to the rise of Cognitive Science, combining multiple disciplines:

- Cognitive Psychology
- Linguistics
- Computer Science
- Philosophy
- Neurobiology

- Focus: Understanding how we process information, think logically, store memories and make decisions.

⇒ Major Perspectives in Psychology:

Perspective	Focus Area	Key Assumption/Example
Biological	Brain, hormones and genetics	Behavior is influenced by biological structures and chemical processes. Ex: Depression may be caused by low serotonin level.
Behavioral	Learning from environment	Behavior is shaped through conditioning and reinforcement. Ex: A child learns to say "thank you" after being praised.
Cognitive	Mental Processes	Focuses on how people think, understand and remember. Ex: Problem-solving or decision-making strategies.

Paper King

Psychoanalytic	Unconscious motives	Founded by Freud; behavior is driven by unconscious desires and childhood conflicts. Ex: Phobias may reflect repressed fears.
Humanistic	Free will and growth	Emphasizes human potential, self-actualization and personal growth. Ex: People strive to become the best version of themselves.
Socio-cultural	Society & culture	Behavior is influenced by social norms, traditions, and cultural expectations. Ex: Collectivist vs. individualist cultures affect family roles.
Evolutionary	Adaption and survival	Human traits evolved to enhance survival and reproduction. Ex: Fear of snakes may be an evolved protective response.

⇒ Perception, Thinking and the Stroop Effect:

- Automaticity: When task become so familiar that they require little conscious effort.
Ex: Reading
- Stroop Effect: Demonstrates interference between automatic and controlled processes.

⇒ Mental Health (According to WHO, 2022):

Mental health is a state of mental well-being that enables people to cope with life's stresses, realize their abilities, learn well and work well, and contribute to their community.

- Key Take ways:

1. Mental health ≠ just the absence of mental illness.
→ Also means positive psychological functioning.

2. Includes emotional, psychological and social well-being.

→ How we feel, think and relate to others.

3. Influenced by individual, social and structural factors — such as genetics, environment, and community support.

4. Mental health can change over time, depending on life circumstances.

→ For instance, stress, loss or trauma can affect well-being.

⇒ Objectives of Psychology: Psychology aims to understand and explain human thought and behavior through the following:

- Describe how people behave.
- Explain why they behave that way.
- Predict future behavior based on observation.
- Control or influence behavior positively (e.g., therapy, education, workplace training).

It studies:

- How our minds interpret sensory information (what we see, hear, taste, feel).
- How we think learn and remember.
- How we interact socially and make moral or emotional decisions.

⇒ Psychology's subfields:

Subfields	Description
Experimental Psy - -	The process of sensing, perceiving, learning and thinking about the world.

Developmental Psy-	Growth and change across lifespan.
Counseling Psy--	Helping individuals achieve personal well-being.
Clinical Psy---	Diagnosis and treatment of mental disorder.
Educational Psy--	Learning and teaching method.
Environmental Psy--	Relationship between people and their physical environment.
Social Psy---	how people's thoughts, feelings and actions are affected by others.
Health Psy---	Relationship between psychological factors and physical ailments or diseases.
Cognitive Psy--	Higher mental process.
School Psy--	Counseling children with academic or emotional problems.
Industrial/Organizational psy-	Psychology of workplace.
Sport Psy--	Applies psychology to athletic activity and exercise.